



Thailand — it appeared ready for the challenge.

The players rose to the occasion. With a revamped and inexperienced forward line in the absence of veteran Vandana Katariya, everyone had to adapt to new roles and responsibilities. With an average age of 21.5 years, it was perhaps one of the youngest Indian attacks in recent times. Sangita Kumari, Deepika, and Beauty Dung Dung, bolstered by the comeback of experienced Preeti Dubey and supported by Sharmila Devi and Lalremsiami, proved up to the task.

The midfield also held firm, with Sushila Chanu making a comeback and Neha Goyal — putting her wedding preparations on hold — serving as the heart of the team. **The defence line was equally impressive, conceding just two goals through the league stage** — off a penalty corner (PC) and a penalty stroke (PS), both to Korea. Even more impressive was the fact that the Indian defence of Udita, Jyoti and Ishika conceded just

seven PCs through the competition!

“Our first priority is to keep a clean sheet and not concede goals, and I’m happy we managed that. Yes, scoring is important, but you must first protect your own goal before attacking the opposition’s. On that count, I’m satisfied with my girls,” Harendra said.

According to the players, the biggest shift has been in the combination of mental and physical fitness. “We dance, laugh, and have fun on the team bus, in the dressing room, and before the game. That helps create a positive environment, keeps us happy and fresh, and reflects on the field. It may not seem like much, but it plays a big role,” explained Salima Tete, shouldering the captaincy responsibilities at the age of 22. “Goal ki bhookh (hunger for goals)” is how Sangita describes the team’s mindset on the field. Improved physical fitness translates to sharper decision-making, sustained pressure on opponents, and quicker exploitation of errors.

Leading from the front: Salima Tete (L), at 22, spearheaded India’s unbeaten run throughout the tournament.

However, there are areas of concern. India’s finishing remains a work in progress, with shots on target yielding fewer goals than expected. The semifinal against Japan was a massive wake-up call, with the inexperienced Japanese side forcing India to work hard for a narrow win. The team must realise that mistakes it got away with here will be punished by stronger opponents.

With the Hockey India League approaching, the Pro League will be the next opportunity for this squad to play together for India. **Until then, there is much work to do if this group of players is to achieve the ambitious goal of a medal at the 2026 World Cup.** The ACT, hopefully, has provided enough pointers in the right direction.